Photographs by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR





GRIM PICKINGS (Above) An e-waste dump in Mustafabad, New Delhi; a worker sifts through electronic equipment to extract precious metals at a recycling centre in the locality

DISMANTLERS

Informal recycling is prevalent all along the chain when e-waste changes hands. These recyclers cherry-pick and extract valuable material such as gold and copper using crude processes that are hazardous and pollute the environment. There are approved dismantlers as well, who follow due process

DISPOSAL

Toxic material from e-waste, crude leaching processes, etc. is discarded in landfills or municipal drains, often contaminating soil and groundwater

Despite the recycling industry getting formalised, with 472 units in the country, they **handle only 15 per cent** of the total e-waste we generate

THE HAZARDS OF E-REFUSE

"You can't have e-waste without mercury and lead. It's there in every device," says Asif Pasha, who runs EwaRDD Recyclers in Bengaluru and has seen both the informal and formal side of e-waste recycling. Back in the late 1990s, when e-waste was still a foreign concept in India, Pasha dropped out of college following his father's death to take up the family business of extracting metals from electronic devices, informally, like many others in the Goripalya locality of old Bengaluru. In 2009, Pasha set up an industrial unit, as a formal recycler—the first from his locality to make the transition, fitted out with safety gear, dust collectors and fume scrubbers. By the end of that decade, e-waste had become a buzzword—and a growing concern.

"The amounts of e-waste in the informal sector have not re-